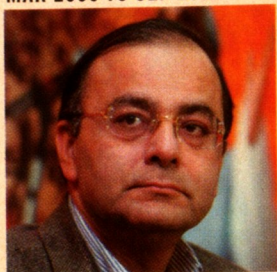


MINISTERS AT ODDS

ARUN JAITLEY, NDA
MAR 2000 TO SEP 2001



HEMANT CHAWLA

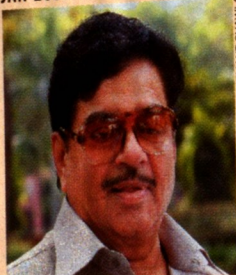
In 2001, when the Environment Ministry rejected the five alignments, he asked for an eco-technological study of the Sethu project.

V.P. GOYAL, NDA
SEP 2001 TO JAN 2003



A sixth alignment that cuts through Adam's Bridge was suggested in 2002. Ministry officials now say that Goyal had endorsed this.

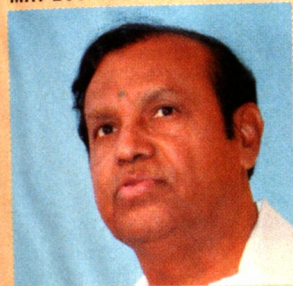
SHATRUGHAN SINHA, NDA
JAN 2003 TO MAY 2004



HEMANT CHAWLA

In a written reply to a Special Mention he talked of an alignment through the bridge. Sinha now says this was never a policy decision.

T.R. BAALU, UPA
MAY 2004 ONWARDS



SHEKHAR GHOSH

Says all the BJP ministers approved of the sixth alignment. Is unhappy with the three-month freeze court order.

electoral issue that could be the sole preserve of BJP seem to have been finally answered. Across the political aisle, Congress President Sonia Gandhi was quick to smell the danger and called the Prime Minister's Office to direct that the affidavit be withdrawn immediately. Not surprising, since it was the same Lord Ram who forever

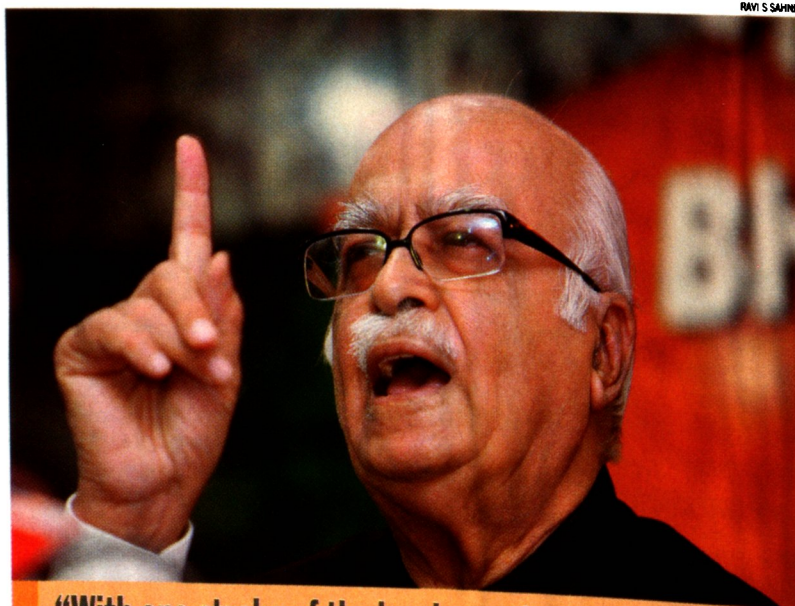
took away the majority vote from the Congress, which it is still to regain. The next day, Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Gopal Subramaniam told the court that the Government "withdraws the present affidavit to re-examine the matter". He added that the Govern-

GODSEND: For the fractious BJP, the issue is manna from heaven

ment was open to any "alternative suggestion". But it was too late. With the nuclear deal making an early election a near certainty, the fractious BJP closed ranks and presumably thanked the Lord for virtually presenting it with such an issue.

Over in the Congress, the knives were out for Soni, industrious and efficient, yet with no dearth of enemies within. They demanded her resignation, with Jairam Ramesh—a Soni loyalist-turned-baiter—firing the first shot. Soon others began taking sides and as the fracas threatened to turn into a full-scale fratricide, Sonia issued a gag order. But the accusations, though muted, continue and the joke in BJP is that a civil war has broken out in the Congress. Since Swamy had demanded that the Ram Sethu be declared an ancient monument, the affidavit drafted by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), under the Ministry of Culture (see box), comes under the scanner. The allies have distanced themselves from the affidavit with Lalu Yadav of the RJD, NCP and the Left calling it a political mistake. "You can't blame ASI. It is a political affidavit," says CPI's D. Raja.

DMK's T.R. Baalu, the Union shipping minister had also filed an affidavit in the same case, claiming that the project in its present form had already



RAVI S SAHNI

"With one stroke of the legal pen, the Government has sought to negate all that Hindus consider sacred."

L.K. ADVANI, LEADER OF OPPOSITION